

News Weekly

Singapore says teachers can cane students as young as 9 in new anti-bullying strategy

Singapore's education minister confirmed teachers can use caning to discipline students in certain cases. "Our schools use caning as a disciplinary measure if all the other measures are inadequate, given the gravity of the misconduct," Desmond Lee said in parliament on Tuesday in response to questions about new anti-bullying measures announced on April 15 – including one asking about the mental health impact of caning children as young as 9 years old. "They follow strict protocols to ensure safety for the student. For instance, caning must be approved by the principal and administered only by authorised teachers," he told lawmakers, with the new framework to be rolled out across Singaporean schools from 2027.

"Schools will consider factors such as the maturity of the student and if caning will help the student learn from his mistake and understand the gravity of what he has done," said Lee.

"Schools exercise discretion on whether to use caning as a disciplinary consequence after assessing the circumstances of the offense committed," he added. "This approach is based on research which shows that children and youth learn to make better choices when there are clear boundaries enforced by firm, meaningful consequences," said Lee, claiming that it helps to reduce bullying. The guidelines, which are set out on the Ministry of Education website, specify that only male students can be punished with the cane. "Caning is a disciplinary option for boys only, and for serious offences as a last resort, when absolutely necessary," it says. (Source: CNN)



Tiny Icy World Beyond Pluto Found with Atmosphere

A new study suggests that a tiny, icy world beyond Pluto harbors a thin, delicate atmosphere that may have been created by volcanic eruptions or a comet strike.

Just 300 miles or so across, this mini Pluto is thought to be the solar system's smallest object yet with a clearly detected global atmosphere bound by gravity, said lead researcher Ko Arimatsu of the National Astronomical Observatory of Japan.

"This is an amazing development, but it sorely needs independent verification. The implications are profound if verified," said Southwest Research Institute's Alan Stern, the lead scientist behind NASA's New Horizons mission to Pluto and beyond. He was not involved in the study. If confirmed, the rock would become just the second world past Neptune in our solar system to host an atmosphere — after only Pluto itself.

The finding offers fresh insight into our solar system's farthest, coldest objects in a region known as the Kuiper Belt. Researchers used three telescopes in Japan to observe the object in 2024 as it passed in front of a background star, briefly dimming the starlight.

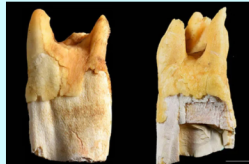
"It changes our view of small worlds in the solar system, not only beyond Neptune," Arimatsu said in an email. Finding an atmosphere around such a small object was "genuinely surprising," he added, and challenges "the conventional view that atmospheres are limited to large planets, dwarf planets and some large moons."



Neandertals' Secret Tool: Rhino Teeth Used for Crafting and Processing, Study Reveals

Neandertals may have had an unexpected tool: rhinoceros teeth. Marks on fossil rhino teeth found in French and Spanish caves suggest they were used as heavy-duty tools. A study reveals that these ancient hominids used the massive molars for shaping stone tools and processing materials like vegetable fibers or hides.

While rhinos no longer roam wild in Europe, about 100,000 years ago, Neandertals coexisted with species like the narrow-nosed rhinoceros. New research, published in the *Journal of Human Evolution*, suggests that rhinoceros teeth were versatile tools due to their hardness and durability. Archaeologists knew Neandertals used bones and antlers as hammers, but few studied teeth. Intrigued by marked teeth, Alicia Sanz-Royo and colleagues surveyed archaeological sites in France and Spain. In El Castillo and Pech-de-l'Azé II, they found teeth with grooves and scrapes, indicating repeated use. Microscopic analysis showed these markings weren't from chewing or natural damage. Using modern rhino teeth, researchers reenacted Neandertal tasks, such as using teeth as hammers and anvils. The experiments damaged the modern teeth in patterns similar to the fossils. (Source: Science News)



Strongman claims latest world record by pulling 21,000-lb bus with his NECK

Strongman Egmond Molina (Aruba) has claimed the latest in a string of impressive world records by moving a bus with nothing but his neck.

The 49-year-old smashed the record for heaviest vehicle pulled by the neck when he dragged a bus weighing 9,860 kg (21,737 lb) over a 20-m course on 9 January. He beat the previous record of 8,060 kg (17,769.26 lbs) set by Dmytro Hrunskyi (Ukraine) in 2024.

But this is just the latest in a long list of strength records Egmond has claimed through sheer grit and determination.

He's done it all to make his four kids, Nigel, Egmond Junior, Benjamin, and Adelinda proud. He said: "My mission is to leave a legacy of discipline for them and for the youth of my island."

"It is a privilege to share my journey. As a representative of my beautiful home, Aruba, a small island with a population of only 110,000. I aim to show the world that greatness can come from even the smallest corners of the globe. (Source: Guinness World Records)



Scientists have created the first "smell map," a one of a kind achievement

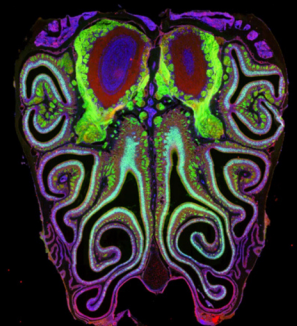
Smell shapes how we experience the world every day. It helps us detect hazards, adds depth to flavor, and connects strongly to memory and emotion. Despite its importance, scientists have struggled to fully understand how this sense works at a biological level.

"Olfaction is super-mysterious," said Sandeep (Robert) Datta, professor of neurobiology in the Blavatnik Institute at Harvard Medical School. Compared with vision, hearing, and touch, the basic biology of smell has remained less understood.

In a new study using mice, Datta and his colleagues built the first detailed map showing how more than a thousand types of smell receptors are arranged inside the nose. What they found challenges long-standing assumptions. Instead of being randomly distributed, the neurons that carry these receptors are highly organized. They form horizontal bands, or stripes, running from the top of the nose to the bottom, grouped by receptor type.

"Our results bring order to a system that was previously thought to lack order, which changes conceptually how we think this works," said Datta, senior author of the study. The researchers also showed that this map in the nose aligns with corresponding maps in the olfactory bulb of the brain. This connection offers new insight into how scent information travels from the nose into neural circuits. The findings published April 28 in *Cell*. Scientists have long understood how sensory receptors are arranged in the eyes, ears, and skin, and how those patterns connect to the brain. Smell has been the exception.

"Olfaction has been the one exception; it's the sense that has been missing a map for the longest time," Datta said. (Source: Science Daily)



Riddle

Why can you never
trust atoms?

Pips



12	14	5		3	6		2		8	13	16	10	9	7	
2	15		6	5	4	14	12		7	1	9	11	16	8	
11		13		1		7	10			5		2		15	
10	7	1		13	16			2			6	12	4	14	5
			3					7	10	9			13		
	10	9	1	16	13	11						14		12	
	11		13	9	1			14		4	5	15	3	2	6
14		4	5	6	3	2		8		16		7			9
			11	7	10	1	9	4		14		6	2		15
	5			15	2		6	16	13	8	11		10	1	7
9	1	7	10	8	11	13	16		3		2	4			
6			2		12		4	9	1			16	11		
	4		14	2	15		3	13		11		1			10
						9		5	4		14	3		6	
	6	2	15		14	4	5	1	9	10	7			16	
1		10	7	11	8		13	3		2				4	12

Pinapple Lemon Mojito

- Ingredient:**
- Pineapple slices
 - Lemon/Lime juice
 - Ice cubes
 - Mint leaves
- Instructions**
- Elegantly blend the succulent pineapples
 - Gracefully add the refreshing lemon or lime juice
 - Adorn with ice cubes and a sprig of mint leaves

